



GROUP 10

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Brand Repositioning & Marketing Strategies (GenZ&Millennials)

RESEARCH OBJECTIVE

Understand what it takes to convert a Gen Z or younger Millennial consumer into a C21 visitor, and build the strategic blueprint to make it repeatable.

CORE RESEARCH QUESTION

1 Purchase Behavior

What motivates or inhibits young consumers from shopping at off-price stores? What drives the decision to visit or not?

2 Brand Perception

How do young consumers perceive C21 specifically? Where does the gap between assumed and actual reality lie?

3 Channel & Discovery

Through which channels do young consumers discover off-price retailers? What content or trigger finally converts awareness into a store visit?

METHODOLOGY

1. IN-DEPTH INTERVIEWS

- **Format:** Semi-structured interviews
- **Mode:** Zoom / In-person
- **Duration:** 45–60 minutes per interview

- Participant Composition (N=8)
- C21 Shoppers: 63%
- Off-price Shoppers (No C21): 37%

1. FOCUS GROUPS

- **Format:** Moderated group discussion
- **Mode:** Zoom (video-on)
- **Duration:** 90 minutes per session

- Participant Composition (N=7)
- Gen Z / Columbia University Student (no prior Century 21 experience)

BRAND PERCEPTION

FINDING 01
Misperceptions of C21 Are Information-Driven and Fixable
Gen Z lacks direct experience of C21. What they hold instead is a passively inherited image of off-price stores: “tourist spot,” “chaotic shelves,” “only extreme sizes.” None of it firsthand.

FINDING 02
Gen Z shops for value, not for discounts.
They frame off-price as “the real thing at the price it deserves.” Price is confirmation, not motivation.

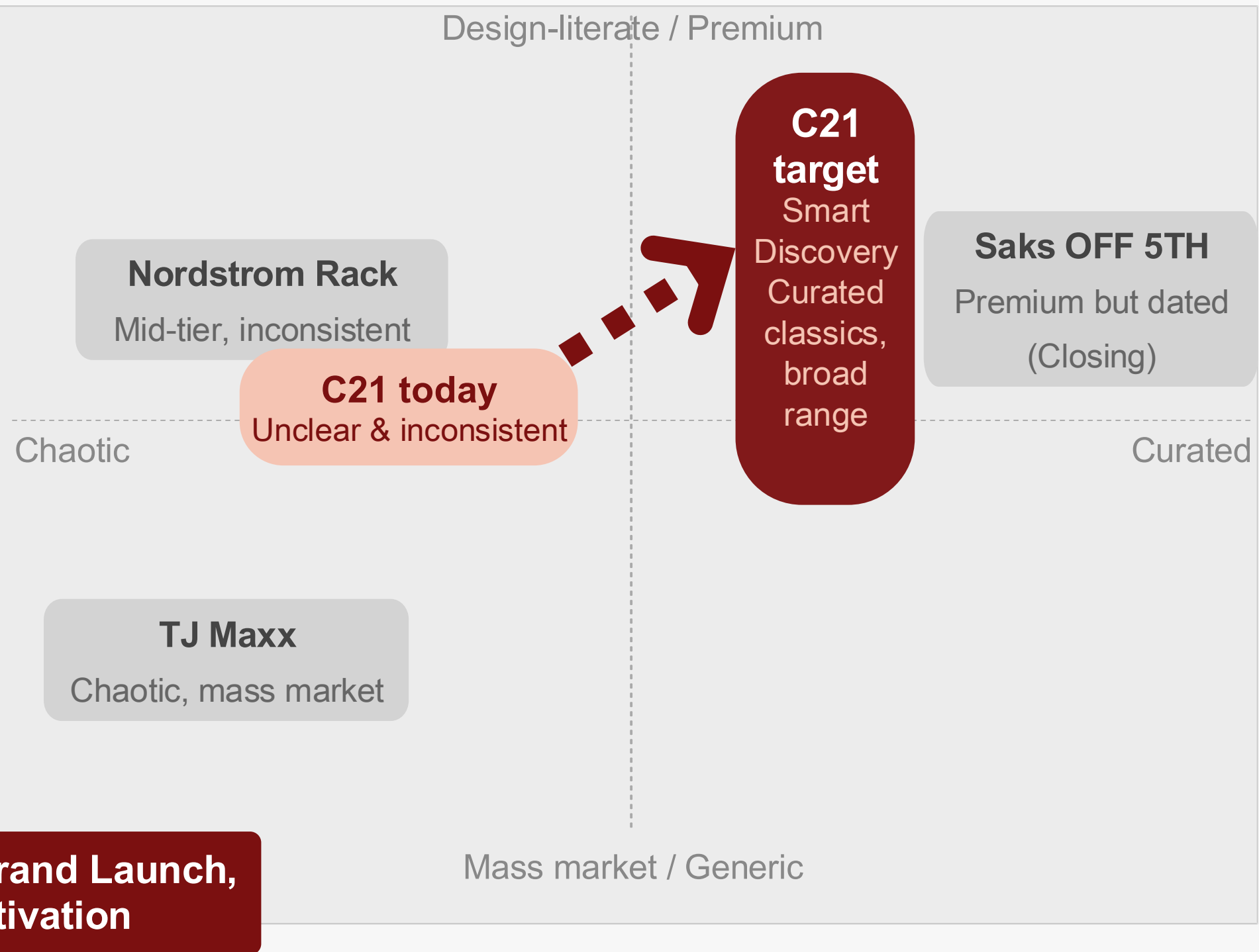
FINDING 03
Fragmented Signals Weaken Brand Positioning
C21’s mixed social styles and broad in-store assortment—from luxury goods to tourist T-shirts and daily items—make its positioning feel unclear.

INSIGHT 01
C21 has a proxy problem, not a product problem.
The perception gap is built entirely on wrong signals — not bad experiences. Fix what is seen before a visit and the product closes the deal on its own.

INSIGHT 02
The target white space is unclaimed.
No existing off-price retailer combines a curated layout and a wide range from everyday classics to premium designer brands. C21 can own this quadrant before anyone else does.

INSIGHT 03
Signal alignment is the prerequisite for everything downstream.

COMPETITIVE MENTAL MAP



BRAND MESSAGING

“Good taste. Better price.”

POSITIONING STATEMENT

Century 21 is where the fashion-literate shop first — designer brands, timeless quality, and everyday pieces, all at the price they should have been from the start.

Not a discount store. Not a compromise. The smart find you didn't know you were looking for.

Every other off-price retailer asks you to lower your standards and get lucky. C21 asks you to raise your eye and be rewarded.

FROM

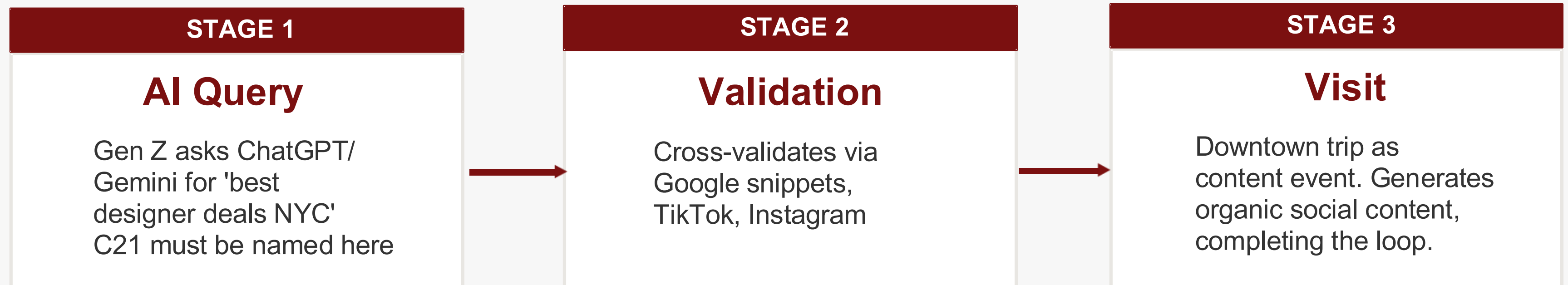
Low-price / high-discount retailer

TO

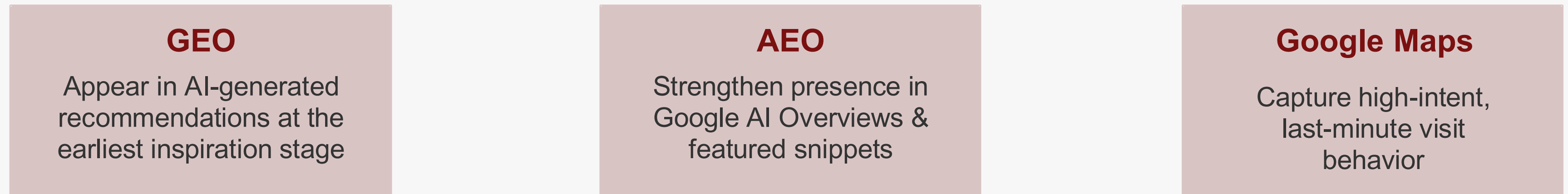
Curated treasure hunt for quality style at the best price

The Multi-face Gen Z Discovery Journey

FINDINGS & INSIGHTS



How Century 21 Must Show Up Across the Journey



The Multi-face Gen Z Discovery Journey

Recommendation

GEO & AEO

Generative + Answer Engine Optimization

1 Lock the Brand Descriptor String

Embed verbatim across website footer, About page, GBP & all PR Releases

2 Build Entity Authority

Update Wikipedia, claim Google Knowledge Panel, submit Wikidata entity, and publish Schema.org/Store structured data — the raw material AI systems pull from.

3 Phrase-Anchor Content for AI Retrieval

Launch an FAQ page targeting Gen Z queries ('best off-price stores NYC') and a blog series comparing C21 prices vs. retail — written in direct, declarative sentences LLMs quote from.

GOOGLE MAPS

Local SEO & Google Business Profile

1 Optimize Google Business Profile

Upload photos (brand sections, fitting rooms, packed racks). Pre-populate Q&A." Enable messaging with 2-hr response window.

2 Post Weekly GBP Updates

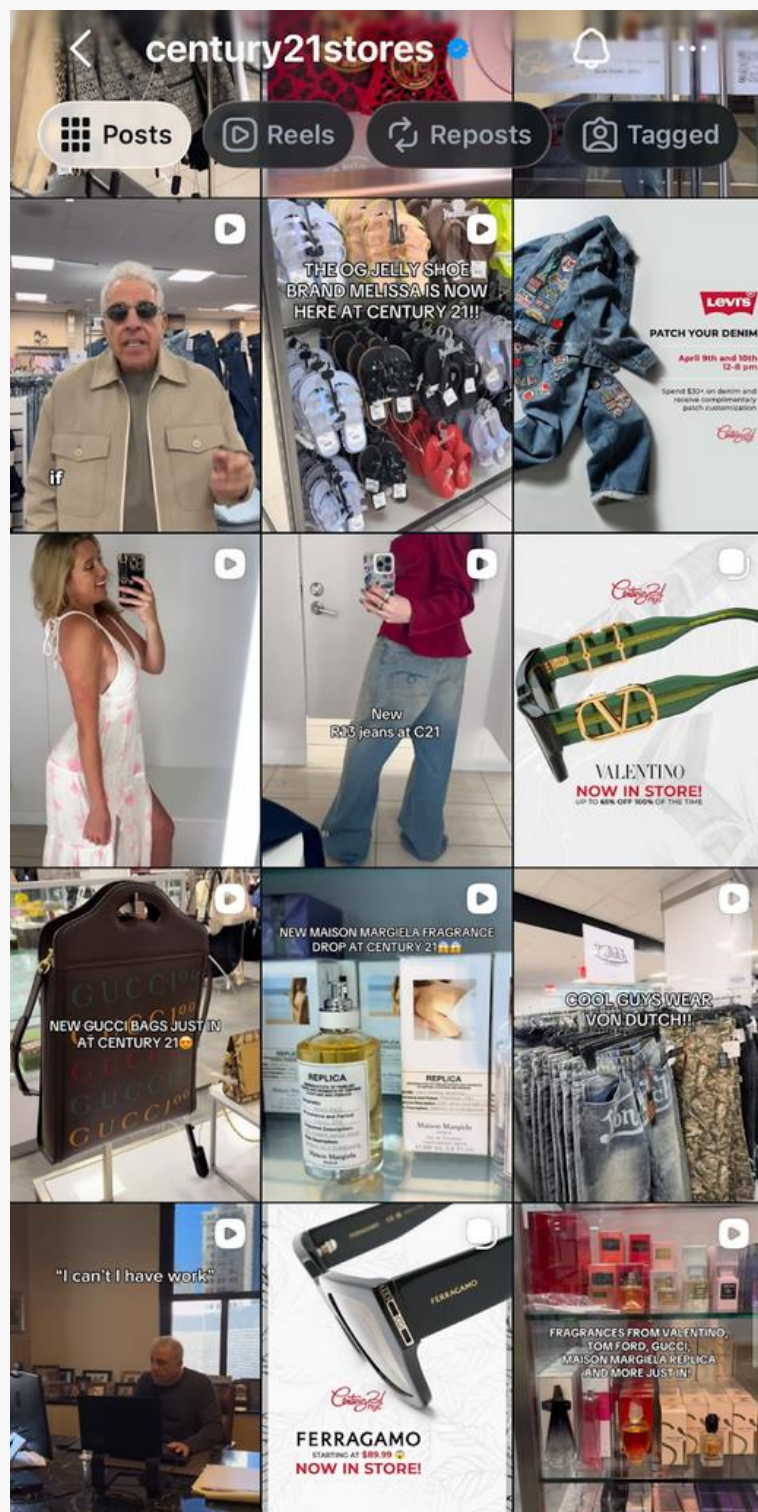
New arrivals, flash sales, in-store events — signals content freshness to Google's local ranking algorithm and keeps C21 surfacing above competitors in Maps results.

3 Bundle C21 into Downtown NYC Itineraries

Pitch 'Perfect Downtown NYC Day' content to Time Out NY — trusted by Gen Z for local recs and highly authoritative to Google. Seed organic mentions on Reddit and TikTok to meet Gen Z where they actually make shopping decisions."

SOCIAL MEDIA ACCOUNT

Key Findings



Digital Discovery

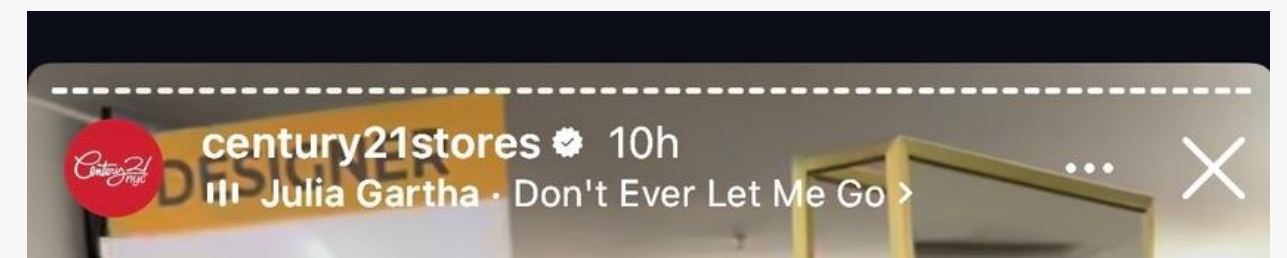
1. Instagram and TikTok are primary brand discovery gateways. High-urgency CTAs like restock alerts drive store visits.

The Gender Information Gap

2. Men's high-value categories are rarely promoted online. A digital heads-up on men's stock could be an effective foot traffic driver for this segment.

Instagram Strategy Critique

3. Stacking 20–50 Story frames daily causes cognitive overwhelm. Mixed aesthetics and inconsistent presentation makes the profile difficult to navigate.



Insight

High-volume information dump



Curated editorial destination

· eliminate friction · reduce user drop-off · build the brand equity

SOCIAL MEDIA ACCOUNT

Recommendation - Unified Brand Identity & Visual Cohesion

Scalable Consistency via AIGC Integration

Adopt an AIGC-enabled workflow to solve the speed versus quality trade-off, especially for background replacement, color grading, and template generation.

Triple-Tiered Account Architecture

Restructure the social presence into a three-account matrix. The main account serves for some store-wide announcements, while the gender-segmented channels act as high-intent catalogs.

Strategic Content Management

Strictly manage how third-party content appears on the profile. For influencer partnerships, utilize the 'Collaborator' feature but remove the post from the profile grid.



Rapid production of visuals while maintaining a high-end visual identity.



Direct category-specific updates to the relevant audiences.



The content still reaches the target audience while keeping the main grid polished.



SOCIAL MEDIA MARKETING

FINDINGS

F1: Result Over Process

Consumers trust creators who show the outcome and explain the reasoning — not those who film the browsing process.

Both polished lookbooks and authentic try-ons work, but only when they answer "why is this worth buying?"

F2: Sharing Already Happens

Privately C21 customers already share their finds in group chats and DMs. This organic behavior exists across all IDI participants. What's missing is a public structure to scale it.

F3: Lead With Brand, Close With Price

Content that establishes brand credibility first — then reveals the C21 price — simultaneously triggers the desire to visit and the impulse to share. This reframes the purchase from "buying something cheap" to "finding something valuable at the price it deserved."

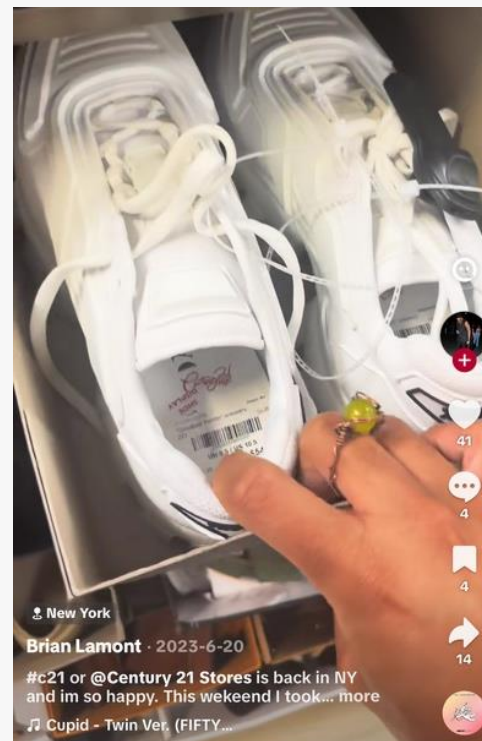
CORE INSIGHT

C21's external marketing problem is not a lack of content — it is a lack of the right content structure.

Consumers already share their finds.

Creators already make authentic videos.

What's missing is a brief that tells them: lead with the brand, close with the price, and show the result — not the process.



SOCIAL MEDIA MARKETING

Aspiration + Validation Content Funnel

Two Stages, One Journey

Aspiration alone doesn't convert;
validation alone doesn't inspire

Stage 1 – Aspiration

Polished editorial KOL content
Lead with brand identity · build desire
· price reveal last

Stage 2 – Validation

Authentic try-on & UGC challenge content
Lead with brand identity · build desire
· price reveal last

Store visit

Generates organic content
· completes the loop

organic
sharing
loop

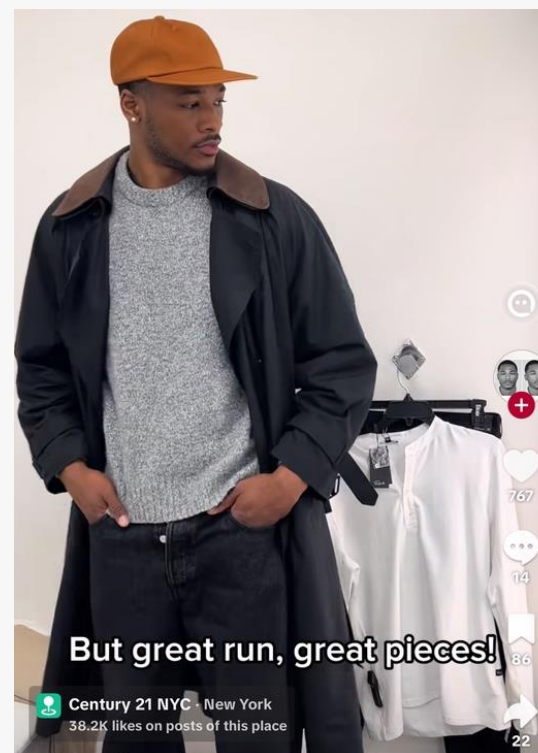
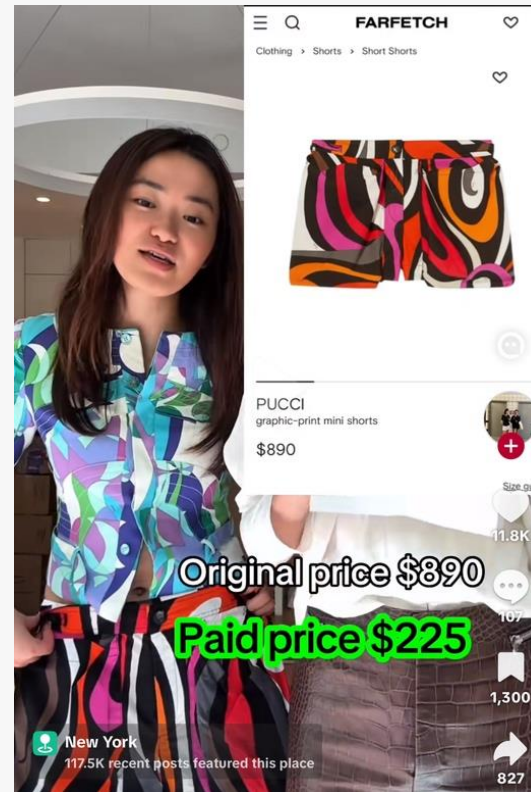
R1 | KOL Partnership

Outcome-Driven, Not Process-Driven

I1 — the right KOL is the one
whose content does the
validation job, not the most
followed

Recommendation

- Select by judgment, not reach — creator must show result + explain reasoning
- Brief: authentic unboxing / styling / try-on, not "shop with me" vlogs



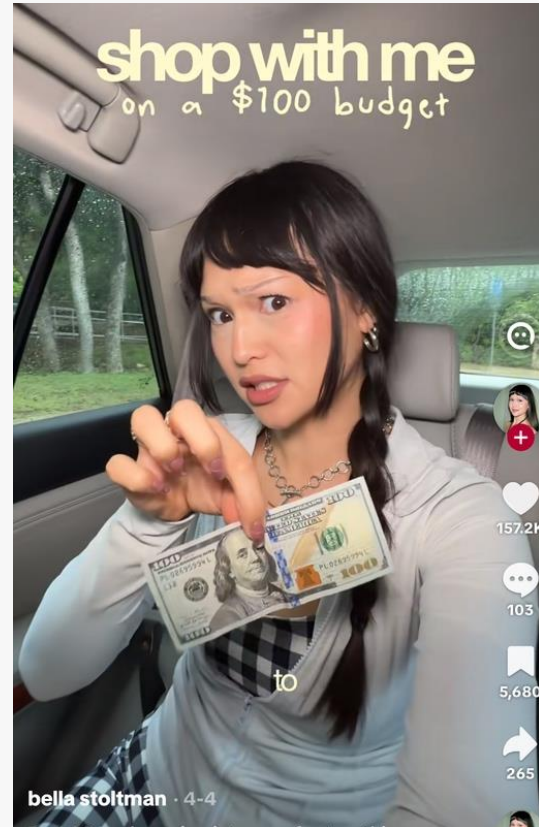
R2 | UGC Challenge Campaign

"What Can You Build at C21 for \$200?"

I2 — organic sharing already exists
in private; this campaign gives it a
public stage

Recommendation

- Fixed budget challenge: reveal brand name + original price + C21 price
- Amplify via branded hashtag, community voting, prizes for top entries



O2O EXPERIENCE

KEY FINDINGS

Email works when it's specific, not promotional

Participants responded to personalized, product-specific alerts tied to what they already care about. Generic discount blasts are ignored.

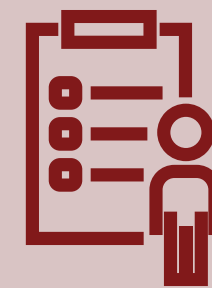
This cohort needs a concrete reason to make the trip

Scarcity, a confirmed brand in stock, or a time-limited event are the real triggers. Awareness alone doesn't convert.

Word of mouth and online discovery are one loop

Friends are the most trusted trigger, but friends find things online first. The two channels feed each other.

MAIN INSIGHTS



Email should work as

Personalized shopper

C21 already has the purchase data — the opportunity is to use it. Send the right product to the right person at the right moment.



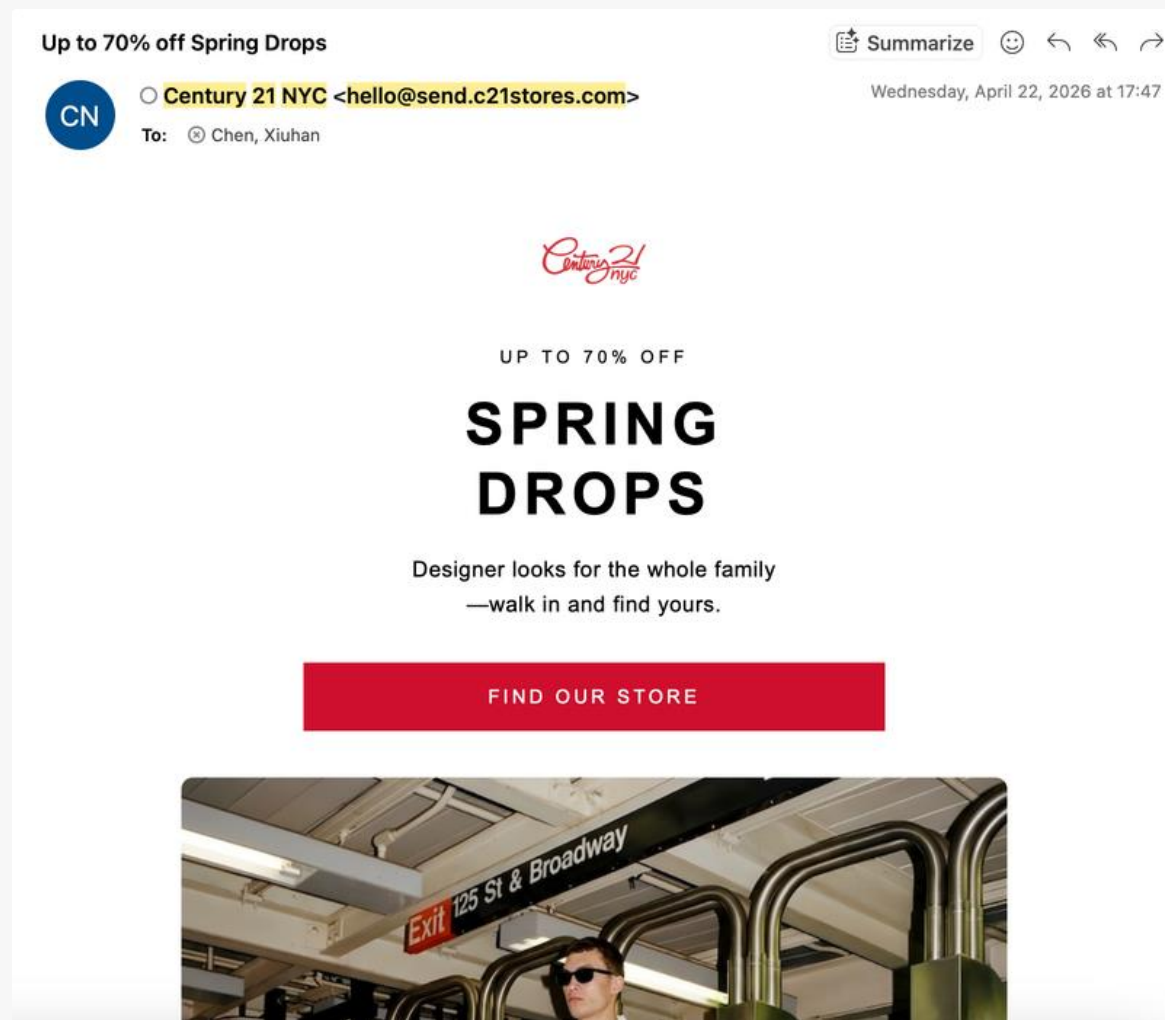
Highlight

Reason to visit

C21 needs to actively create recurring, compelling visit occasions, so that coming in becomes a habit, not a one-time decision.

O2O EXPERIENCE

CURRENT GAP



- Generic discount-led ("UP TO 70% OFF")
- No personalization
- No scarcity signal
- CTA not strong enough

RECOMMENDATION

Monthly themed pop-ups at WTC

Limited selection, explicit scarcity, photo-worthy moment to seed organic sharing.

Drives foot traffic → builds loyalty → upgrades brand perception

Email as the connective tissue

Personalized by purchase history, specific brands and products, clear scarcity signal: "this weekend only," "in-store only."

Showcases assortment strength through relevance

